

Lesson Plan — French Revolution

History | Grade 9-10 | Intermediate | French Revolution

Overview

Subject	History
Grade band	9-10
Topic	French Revolution
Chapter	French Revolution
Source document	French Revolution
Periods	7 x 40 min

Learning Objectives

- [analyze] Analyze and list the multiple long-term and short-term social, economic, financial and political factors that the document identifies as causes of the French Revolution, citing specific evidence.
- [understand] Explain the sequence of events by which the Estates General of 1789 led to the Third Estate declaring itself the National Assembly, using specific dated actions from the text.
- [analyze] Interpret the scale and mechanisms of repression during the Reign of Terror and evaluate differing historical interpretations presented in the document.
- [understand] Describe the measures taken against the Catholic Church (confiscation of property, abolition of tithes, Civil Constitution of the Clergy) and explain one social consequence the document attributes to these measures.
- [apply] Use passages from the document to illustrate how newspapers and pamphlets influenced public debate during the Revolution and identify one example given.

Period-by-Period Plan

Period 1: Origins and Opening Acts of 1789

Concepts	French Revolution (overview), Dates of the French Revolution, Storming of the Bastille
Objectives	Analyze and list the multiple long-term and short-term social, economic, financial and political factors that the document identifies as causes of the French Revolution, citing specific evidence.
Time allocation	Activate prior knowledge: quick whole-class brainstorm on what students already know about 'revolution' and symbols (record answers on board to compare with primary-source evidence) (5 min), Introduce core content with evidence: teacher-led, evidence-centred mini-lecture presenting the Revolution's dated span (5 May 1789–9 Nov 1799) and the Storming of the Bastille (14 July 1789), citing primary descriptions and contemporary reactions and noting competing interpretations of the Bastille's meaning

(7 min), Small-group source analysis: students examine short excerpts (or teacher-read summaries) describing causes (social, economic, financial, political) and the Bastille; groups list specific short- and long-term causes named in the texts and mark which are supported by direct evidence vs interpretation (12 min), Structured debate / role-play: groups represent different perspectives (peasantry, urban workers, nobility, political intellectuals) and argue which causes mattered most, using evidence from the documents and acknowledging other views (10 min), Check for understanding: teacher-led class debrief with targeted questions (ask students to cite one specific piece of evidence for a short-term cause and one for a long-term cause) and quick written exit ticket (4 min), Consolidate: teacher summarizes where evidence is strong or contested and explains how this foundation will help analyse the Reign of Terror and the Estates General in upcoming periods (2 min)

Why this order

As the opening period, this lesson introduces the French Revolution (its dated span and the Storming of the Bastille) and so equips students with the timeline and symbolic events they must use when studying the Reign of Terror, the multifactor causes of the Revolution, and the Estates General/National Assembly in later periods.

Period 2: Causes, Estates General, and the Terror

Concepts

Reign of Terror (1793–1794), Causes of the Revolution (multifactor), Estates General of 1789 and National Assembly

Objectives

Analyze and list the multiple long-term and short-term social, economic, financial and political factors that the document identifies as causes of the French Revolution, citing specific evidence.; Explain the sequence of events by which the Estates General of 1789 led to the Third Estate declaring itself the National Assembly, using specific dated actions from the text.

Time allocation

Activate prior knowledge: quick recap of Origins and Opening Acts (dates, Bastille, role of Estates General) with students citing one prior fact aloud (5 min), Introduce new material: teacher-led presentation of Estates General 1789 National Assembly sequence (May–June 1789) and factual overview of the Reign of Terror (Sept 1793–July 1794), citing numbers and primary evidence (8 min), Small-group source analysis: groups examine short extracts (causes list: population growth, bad harvests, tax system, Enlightenment) and annotate which are long-term vs short-term, citing textual evidence (12 min), Structured role-play debate: two groups (moderates vs radicals) use evidence to argue which causes mattered most and whether the National Assembly's actions justified emergency measures leading to the Terror (10 min), Check for understanding: targeted exit questions where students list two causes with evidence and one dated step from Estates General/National Assembly (3 min), Consolidate and next steps: teacher highlights competing interpretations from the session and assigns brief written evidence citation linking one cause to later events for homework (2 min)

Why this order

This period builds on Origins and Opening Acts of 1789 by using the

Storming of the Bastille and earlier dates to explain how the Estates General led the Third Estate to form the National Assembly; it also sets up how those political changes and competing views about crisis management made the Reign of Terror possible and prepares students for studying the Declaration of the Rights of Man and related reforms.

Period 3: Church Reform, Rights, and Social Impact

Concepts	Declaration of the Rights of Man and of the Citizen, Abolition of feudalism and related August Decrees, Civil Constitution of the Clergy and church property
Objectives	Describe the measures taken against the Catholic Church (confiscation of property, abolition of tithes, Civil Constitution of the Clergy) and explain one social consequence the document attributes to these measures.
Time allocation	Activate prior knowledge: brief class recap linking Causes, Estates General and the Reign of Terror (3 quick prompts for students to recall estates, privileges, and earlier violence) (5 min), Introduce new material: teacher-led evidence session presenting the Declaration of the Rights of Man, the August Decrees on abolition of feudalism, and the Civil Constitution of the Clergy with short quoted excerpts as primary sources (10 min), Group source analysis: small groups read 2 short excerpts (one on confiscation/abolition of tithes; one on Civil Constitution) and identify claimed effects and any bias or silences in the sources (12 min), Role-play debate: two groups (parish priests/Catholic peasants vs. revolutionary officials/landowners) present short arguments about social consequences and resistance, citing evidence from the excerpts (8 min), Check for understanding: individual exit ticket—write one clear social consequence the class sources attribute to church reforms and note an alternative interpretation or missing perspective (3 min), Consolidate and bridge: teacher summarizes competing interpretations and links how these disputes help explain subsequent repression in the Terror and Thermidor (2 min)
Why this order	This period builds on the earlier study of Causes, Estates General, and the Terror by explaining the Assembly's concrete reforms (Declaration, August Decrees) that attacked old privileges and church power; it prepares learners to evaluate how those reforms fed into later Repression during the Terror, the Law of 22 Prairial, and Thermidor. It connects legal measures to social reactions and conflict that follow in the next period.

Period 4: Repression, Law of 22 Prairial, Thermidor

Concepts	Repression during the Terror, Law of 22 Prairial (10 June), Thermidor and execution of Robespierre
Objectives	Interpret the scale and mechanisms of repression during the Reign of Terror and evaluate differing historical interpretations presented in the document.
Time allocation	Activate prior knowledge: small-group recall of the Civil Constitution,

August Decrees and popular expectations (students list links between earlier reforms and rising tensions) (5 min), Introduce new material: teacher-led evidence tour of the Terror (primary-source extracts on drownings at Nantes, excerpts on Law of 22 Prairial, and accounts of Robespierre's arrest and execution) with teacher modelling how to weigh conflicting claims (10 min), Practise interpretation: jigsaw group work where each group examines one claim (scale of deaths, legal changes under 22 Prairial, motives for Robespierre's fall) and prepares short argument citing the documents and alternative interpretations (12 min), Check whether it landed: structured debate and role-play (groups present opposing interpretations; one student plays a contemporary critic, another a revolutionary defender) with teacher questioning on causation and perspective (8 min), Consolidate: whole-class synthesis listing agreed certainties, contested points, and how this period leads into Thermidorian reaction and the Directory (5 min)

Why this order This period builds on Church Reform, Rights, and Social Impact by showing how revolutionary legal changes and social tensions escalated into state repression under the Terror; it prepares students to analyse the Thermidorian reaction and the Directory by examining why Robespierre fell and how the scale and mechanisms of repression were contested.

Period 5: Directory, War Mobilisation and Thermidor

Concepts Thermidorian reaction and aftermath, Constitution of Year III and Directory institutions, War mobilisation and scope of the Revolutionary Wars, Fall of the Monarchy and Proclamation of the Republic

Objectives Interpret the scale and mechanisms of repression during the Reign of Terror and evaluate differing historical interpretations presented in the document.

Time allocation Activate prior knowledge: quick whole-class recap of Thermidor and the Law of 22 Prairial, citing concrete examples of reprisals mentioned in the prior lesson (5 min), Introduce core content: teacher-led evidence summary of the Constitution of Year III, Directory institutions, and scope of Revolutionary Wars, with two short sourced quotations showing competing historians' views on how repressive or stabilising the Directory was (10 min), Small-group document analysis and debate: groups examine a short primary excerpt on Directory property qualifications and a military mobilisation order; each group lists evidence for two competing interpretations (stabilising republic vs. oligarchic rollback) and prepares a 2-minute position (12 min), Role-play: Council simulation where students represent a Director, a Jacobin critic, and a rural delegate debating conscription and property-based voting — focus on causation and perspective, using evidence from documents (8 min), Consolidate and check understanding: exit ticket where students write one piece of evidence supporting each interpretation of the Directory's nature and one question for the next lesson on abolition and propaganda (5 min)

Why this order This period connects the end of the Terror (Thermidor and Robespierre's

execution) to the institutional response in the Constitution of Year III and shows how revolutionary government then organised war mobilisation; it prepares students to study colonial policy, propaganda, and social changes that follow. It builds on the preceding analysis of repression and Law of 22 Prairial and sets up the next topics of abolition of slavery, press and symbols, and women's roles.

Period 6: Media, Symbols, Slavery and Economy

Concepts	Abolition of slavery in the colonies (1794), Role of newspapers and pamphlets, Revolutionary symbols: La Marseillaise and the guillotine, Role of women in the Revolution, Economic policies and assignats
Objectives	Use passages from the document to illustrate how newspapers and pamphlets influenced public debate during the Revolution and identify one example given.
Time allocation	Activate prior knowledge: quick recap of Thermidor, Directory and recent reforms; students list what they already know about newspapers, the guillotine, assignats, abolition and women's roles (paired share) (5 min), Introduce new material: short teacher-led evidence walk-through using passages from the document — the 1794 abolition decree, a quoted pamphlet/newspaper example, assignats policy and inflation data, and competing interpretations about women's political exclusion and the guillotine's symbolism (10 min), Practice (group role-play & analysis): small groups role-play as pamphleteers/newspaper editors or Directory officials drafting a short argument on one prompt (abolition, assignats, or women's clubs); each group must cite one passage from the text as evidence and note an alternative interpretation (12 min), Check for understanding: rapid group presentations (30–40 seconds each) naming the textual example that shows how newspapers influenced debate and teacher-led targeted questions to probe causation and perspective (6 min), Consolidate: whole-class debate linking symbols, media and economic policy — teacher synthesises evidence, highlights unresolved interpretations, and previews which specific follow-up readings will deepen each thread (7 min)
Why this order	This period builds on the political instability and institutional changes studied in 'Directory, War Mobilisation and Thermidor' by showing how media, symbols and economic policy shaped public opinion and policy after the Terror. It prepares students to read the assigned follow-up sources (the Britannica article, Opie on the guillotine, Acemoglu et al., Chisick on pamphlets and the compiled bibliography) by giving concrete examples and evidence from the Revolution for use in those readings.

Period 7: Pamphlets, Newspapers and Public Debate

Concepts	French Revolution (Britannica article citation), Guillotine (Opie 1997 citation), The Consequences of Radical Reform: The French Revolution (Acemoglu et al.), Pamphlets and journalism in the Early French Revolution
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	(Chisick citation), Compiled scholarly bibliography on the French Revolution
Objectives	Use passages from the document to illustrate how newspapers and pamphlets influenced public debate during the Revolution and identify one example given.
Time allocation	Activate prior knowledge: 3-minute quick recall from previous period about newspapers, pamphlets, symbols and assignats; students jot two examples and one question (5 min), Introduce new material: Teacher models close reading of one passage from the document (Chisick/Britannica citation) that shows a pamphlet's claim and identifies the concrete example given (8 min), Guided practice: In small groups students annotate a second short passage from the compiled bibliography, listing evidence that the pamphlet/newspaper influenced public debate and a plausible alternative interpretation (10 min), Debate / role play: Groups adopt roles (publisher, royalist critic, popular reader, historian) and debate whether the pamphlet changed outcomes or merely reflected opinion, citing textual evidence (10 min), Check for understanding: Three groups report one piece of evidence and one counter-interpretation; teacher probes with one focused question per group (4 min), Consolidate and connect: Teacher led synthesis linking the evidence to broader consequences of radical reform (Acemoglu et al.) and noting the bibliography as sources for further study (3 min)
Why this order	This period builds on the prior lesson's focus on the role of newspapers and pamphlets, revolutionary symbols and economic policy by taking primary passages from the compiled bibliography and Chisick citation and using them to test claims about media influence. It prepares students to synthesise evidence, weigh competing interpretations, and evaluate the broader consequences of radical reform discussed in the course.

Concepts Taught

Concept	Importance	Summary
French Revolution (overview)	core	A period of political and societal change in France from the Estates General of 1789 to the Coup of 18 Brumaire on 9 November 1799, with long-term impacts on liberal democracy and French political values.

Concept	Importance	Summary
Dates of the French Revolution	supporting	The Revolution is dated from 5 May 1789 to 9 November 1799 (10 years, 6 months, and 4 days).
Estates General of 1789 and National Assembly	core	The Estates General convened in May 1789; the Third Estate broke away and reconstituted itself as the National Assembly in June 1789.
Storming of the Bastille	core	On 14 July 1789 the Storming of the Bastille in Paris occurred; the Bastille was a potent symbol of the Ancien Régime and was demolished in the following weeks.
Declaration of the Rights of Man and of the Citizen	core	The National Assembly issued the Declaration of the Rights of Man and of the Citizen during the revolutionary period.
Abolition of feudalism and related August Decrees	core	The Assembly issued measures including the abolition of feudalism, cancellation of church tithes, equality before the law, and opening public office to all.
Reign of Terror (1793–1794)	core	From September 1793 to July 1794 the Reign of Terror saw around 300,000 arrests and about 16,600 people executed on charges of counter-revolutionary activity.

Concept	Importance	Summary
Causes of the Revolution (multifactor)	core	The Revolution resulted from multiple long-term and short-term social, economic, financial and political factors, including population growth, economic recession, bad harvests, tax complexity, resistance to reform, and Enlightenment ideas.
Civil Constitution of the Clergy and church property	supporting	The Assembly confiscated church property, abolished tithes, and enacted the Civil Constitution of the Clergy (12 July 1790) making clergy employees of the state; this produced division and resistance among clergy and Catholics.
Fall of the Monarchy and Proclamation of the Republic	core	Military defeats and insurrection culminated in the insurrection of 10 August 1792, the suspension of the monarchy, and replacement by the French First Republic in September 1792; Louis XVI was executed in January 1793.
Repression during the Terror	core	The Terror involved mass executions and repression, including drownings at Nantes and contested high death toll estimates.

Concept	Importance	Summary
Law of 22 Prairial (10 June)	core	The Law of 22 Prairial removed the right of 'enemies of the people' to defend themselves, accelerating executions in Paris.
Thermidor and execution of Robespierre	core	Robespierre was arrested after losing support, taken to the Hotel de Ville, injured attempting suicide, and executed on 28 July with colleagues.
Thermidorian reaction and aftermath	supporting	After Robespierre's fall, revenge killings occurred in southern France; some former Terror figures retained positions while political control shifted.
Constitution of Year III and Directory institutions	core	The Year III constitution (1795) established a bicameral legislature (Council of 500 and Council of Ancients) and a five-director executive with indirect elections and property qualifications.
War mobilisation and scope of the Revolutionary Wars	core	The Revolutionary Wars (beginning 1792) mobilised mass armies, expanded into multiple theatres, and led to annexations and the creation of satellite states.

Concept	Importance	Summary
Abolition of slavery in the colonies (1794)	core	Amid revolts and military actions in Saint-Domingue and other colonies, the Convention abolished slavery in the colonies on 4 February 1794 and granted full rights regardless of colour.
Role of newspapers and pamphlets	supporting	Newspapers and pamphlets proliferated during the Revolution, becoming the main communication medium and stimulating revolutionary debate.
Revolutionary symbols: La Marseillaise and the guillotine	supporting	La Marseillaise became the national anthem after 1795; the guillotine became the principal symbol of the Terror and a part of popular culture.
Role of women in the Revolution	supporting	Women initially participated in activism and organised societies, but the 1791 and 1793 constitutions denied them political rights and women's clubs were banned in October 1793.
Economic policies and assignats	core	The Revolution nationalised church and émigré lands to back paper currency called assignats; over-issuance caused hyperinflation and economic disruption.

Concept	Importance	Summary
French Revolution (Britannica article citation)	supporting	The document cites a Britannica article titled "French Revolution History, Summary, Timeline, Causes, & Facts" (with archive and retrieval information).
Guillotine (Opie 1997 citation)	supporting	The document lists Robert Frederick Opie's 1997 book titled Guillotine as a cited source.
The Consequences of Radical Reform: The French Revolution (Acemoglu et al.)	supporting	The document cites Acemoglu, Cantoni, Johnson & Robinson (2011) "The Consequences of Radical Reform: The French Revolution", with links to NBER and American Economic Review metadata.
Pamphlets and journalism in the Early French Revolution (Chisick citation)	supporting	The document cites Harvey Chisick's work on pamphlets and journalism in the early French Revolution (offices of Ami du Roi of the Abbé Royou).
Compiled scholarly bibliography on the French Revolution	core	The document contains an extensive list of scholarly works and authors on various aspects of the French Revolution (history, social causes, economic effects, cultural studies, further reading).